

Session 11: John the Baptist

Key Takeaways

- Matthew portrays John as the messenger anticipated by Isaiah who will announce the coming of Yahweh to restore his captive people (Isa. 40:3-5).
- John's speech is full of quotes and phrases from the Prophets, recalling repeated themes of God's judgment and God's promise of rescue and restoration.
- Water and fire are complex symbols, representing both judgment and hope, death, and purification.

The Commissioning of the Messiah

A - Matthew 3:1-17

- a - **3:1-6** John **in the wilderness**, a voice calling, Jerus. & Judea come, **"repent, Kingdom of God has arrived!"**, **Old Testament quote 6 (Isa. 40)**
- b - **3:7-12** Zadokites come, John's speech: Who are Abraham's children? Baptism of Spirit & fire
- a' - **3:13-17** Baptism of Jesus: voice from the skies, Spirit descends, "you are my **Son**."

B - Matthew 4:1-11

- a - **4:1** Jesus **in the wilderness**, tested by **slanderer** for 40 days
- b - **4:2-10** Three tests of Jesus' loyalty, "If you are the **Son** of God..." + **3 Old Testament quotes (Deut.)**
- a' - **4:11** **Slanderer** leaves Jesus, **angels** come and serve

A' - Matthew 4:12-17

- **4:12-17** Jesus goes to Nazareth, **"repent, Kingdom of God has arrived"** + **Old Testament quote 7 (Isa. 9:1)**, **light "shining"**

Matthew 3:1-4:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Rise of the Messiah (2024).

This third and final panel of Matthew's introduction (Matt. 1:1-4:17) speeds the clock forward a few decades and focuses on the circumstances that lead to Jesus' entrance onto the scene, beginning with John the Immerser's arrival.

Notice how the entire unit has a three-part shape in a symmetrical design.

- A - John arrives in the wilderness announcing the arrival of the Kingdom of God (Isaiah 40 quote).

- B - Jesus is tested in the wilderness.
- A' - Jesus arrives in Galilee announcing the arrival of the Kingdom of God ([Isaiah 9 quote](#)).

This symmetrical design makes a clear connection and comparison between John and Jesus and their respective messages. Matthew wants to establish continuity between the two figures so that Jesus takes his cue from the renewal movement that John began. But also, Matthew wants to show how both of them continue the script anticipated by Isaiah.

Matthew has also placed key links between A and B.

- A - John arrives in the wilderness. // B - Jesus enters into the wilderness for his test.
- A - John's baptism establishes Jesus as the Son of God. // B - Jesus' status as the Son of God is questioned and tested in the wilderness.
- A - The Spirit of the Father descends upon Jesus at his baptism. // B - The Spirit leads Jesus into the wilderness so that his loyalty to the Father can be tested.

Reflection Question

Reflect on the symbols of water and fire in John's words in [Matthew 3:7-12](#). In what ways are fire and water similar or different? Are they signs of good things or bad?